

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

Same Program, Different Paychecks: Pay, Benefits, and the Parity Gap

Lead-teacher compensation across delivery settings, 2021–22 to 2024–25

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

Every First Class Pre-K classroom operates under the same quality standards and the same state salary schedule, and we examine here whether the teachers in those classrooms are compensated in the same way. We linked 5,753 lead-teacher salary records from the program’s rosters (2021–22 through 2024–25) to the state minimum salary schedule, and we drew on the program’s classroom budget data for benefits. Our analysis shows that public-school teachers are paid, on average, \$3,584 *above* their schedule amount, while Head Start teachers sit \$4,398 below it and other non-public teachers \$5,623 below. The difference in benefits is wider still, at \$20,548 a year in budgeted lead-teacher benefits in public schools versus \$3,617—about \$300 a month—in other non-public settings.

We organize the evidence around four findings:

- **Salaries and the schedule.** The schedule appears to function as a floor only in public schools, where teachers average above schedule, whereas Head Start and other non-public teachers average \$4,400–\$5,600 below it.
- **Experience and pay.** Experience is associated with higher pay in one sector only: from the 0–2-year band to the 21+ band, mean public-school salaries rise by \$17,339, while Head Start and other non-public salaries rise by roughly \$3,100–\$3,600 (figure 1).

- **Budgeted benefits.** Benefits are the widest of the gaps we observe, at \$20,548 (public schools), \$10,848 (Head Start), and \$3,617 (other non-public), and 32.1 percent of other non-public classrooms budget no lead-teacher benefits at all (figure 2).
- **Pay and retention.** Lower pay is associated with higher departure, in that teachers in the lowest-paid fifth left the program at 22.8 percent a year, compared with 14–15 percent among the two highest-paid fifths (figure 3).

These are descriptive patterns drawn from salary and budget records rather than measures of what pay levels *should* be, and they are not causal estimates of what raising pay would do. We return to those limits at the end of the brief.

Mixed Delivery and Compensation Parity

First Class Pre-K’s signature design choice is mixed delivery, so that the same program operates in public schools, Head Start centers, child-care centers, faith-based settings, and private schools. Although that design lets the program grow fast and meet families where they are, it also means that a single workforce, held to a single quality standard, is employed by many kinds of employers with very different pay structures. Brief 6 showed that teachers leave non-public settings at higher rates and that the sector gap survives measurement correction. Here we document the compensation differences that sit alongside that churn.

In this brief, the eighth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, we draw our turnover context from briefs 6 and 7 (Lee and Hooper 2026a, 2026b).

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Salaries. We use First Class Pre-K staff rosters for the 2021–22 through 2024–25 transition years, comprising 5,753 lead-teacher records with a reported annual salary and a matched state minimum salary schedule amount for the teacher’s experience level (records under \$5,000, mostly partial-year, are excluded). We define the “schedule gap” as the teacher’s actual salary minus the schedule amount, and we group delivery settings as public school, Head Start, and other non-public (child care, faith-based, community, private school, university).

Benefits. We draw budgeted lead-teacher benefit amounts from the program’s FY2024–25 classroom budgets, previously verified at the dollar level; budgeted amounts are plans, not benefits received.

Measures. All values are descriptive means or rates over the records described, and we make no causal claims. Sector-level averages pool at least 374 records, whereas experience-by-sector cells are smaller and are flagged where thin.

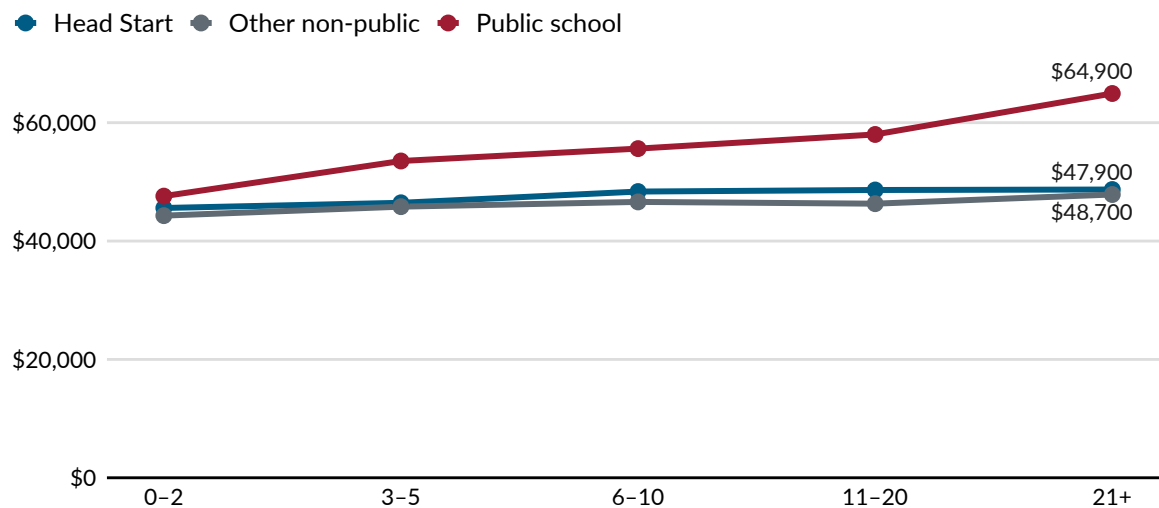
Salaries across Experience Levels and Settings

Alabama publishes a minimum salary schedule that steps upward with experience, and figure 1 shows what teachers actually earn by experience band and setting. In public schools, added experience is associated with substantially higher pay, rising from a \$47,591 average in the first two years to \$64,930 at 21+ years, a difference of \$17,339. Salaries in Head Start and other non-public settings begin in the same range, at about \$44,000–\$48,000, and then change very little, rising about \$3,100–\$3,600 across an entire career.

FIGURE 1

Pay Rises with Experience in Public Schools—and Barely Moves It Elsewhere

Mean lead-teacher salary, by years of experience and delivery setting, 2021–22 to 2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2024–25.

Notes: ADECE = Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education. Lead teachers with reported salaries; cells contain 10–1,193 records (the smallest, Head Start at 0–2 years, is correspondingly noisy). “Other non-public” pools child-care, faith-based, community, private school, and university settings.

Averaged over all experience levels, the same pattern appears as a gap to the schedule, since public-school teachers earn \$3,584 above their schedule amount on average, while Head Start teachers earn \$4,398 below it and other non-public teachers \$5,623 below. Although the schedule applies across all delivery settings, it therefore appears to function as a true minimum only where the employer is a school system; elsewhere it describes a level that many teachers never reach and that added seniority does not appear to deliver.

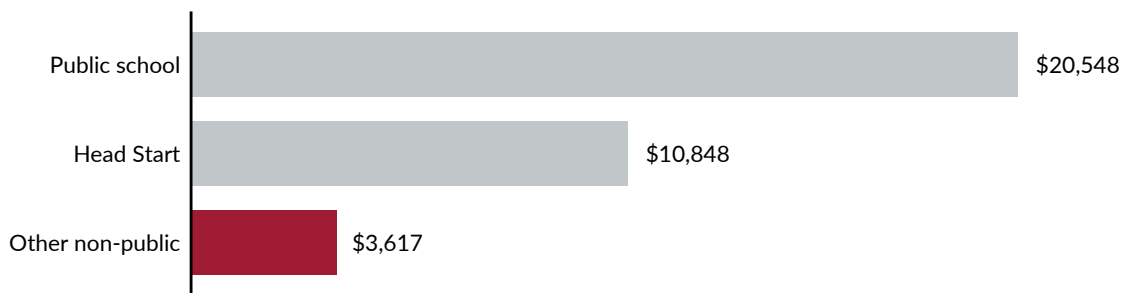
Budgeted Benefits across Settings

Salary alone understates the divide between settings. In the program's FY2024–25 classroom budgets, a public-school classroom budgets \$20,548 a year for its lead teacher's benefits—retirement, health insurance, and the standard public-employee package—whereas a Head Start classroom budgets \$10,848 and other non-public classrooms budget \$3,617, or about \$300 a month. Among other non-public classrooms, 32.1 percent budget nothing at all (figure 2).

FIGURE 2

Public-School Classrooms Budget Nearly Six Times the Benefits of Other Non-Public Settings

Budgeted annual lead-teacher benefits, by delivery setting, FY2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K classroom budget data, FY2024–25.

Notes: Budgeted amounts (approved or amended classroom budgets), not audited expenditures or benefits received. 32.1 percent of other non-public classrooms budget \$0 in lead-teacher benefits.

For a teacher choosing between two First Class classrooms a few miles apart, the same job under the same standards may carry a total-compensation difference that exceeds \$20,000 a year once benefits are counted. That difference describes the environment in which the program's non-public settings compete for teachers, and it is the setting in which we next examine how compensation and retention move together.

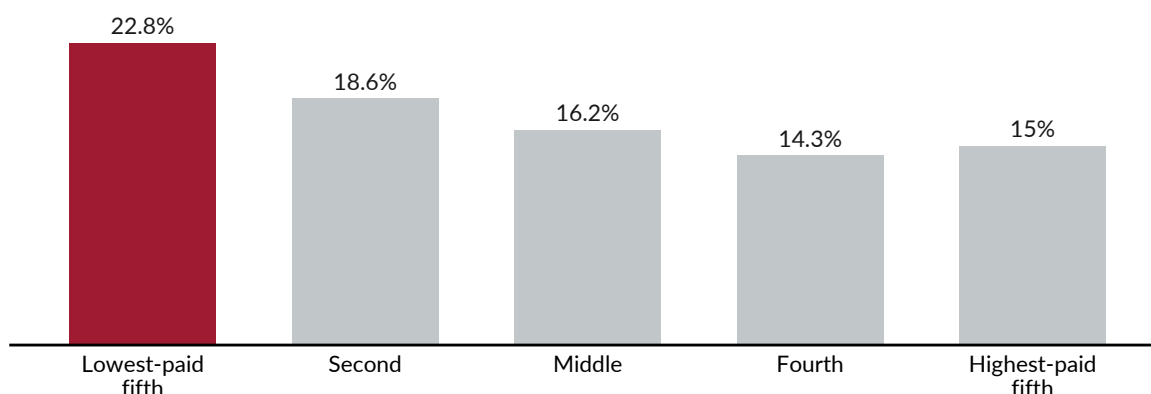
Compensation and Retention

Sorting lead teachers into fifths by salary, we observe that lower pay is associated with higher departure: 22.8 percent of the lowest-paid fifth, whose salaries run up to about \$45,800, left the program in a given year, against 14–15 percent in the two highest-paid fifths (figure 3). The pattern is not confined to a single specification, because across 24 model specifications in the companion technical work, varying controls, samples, and salary measures, the salary–retention association keeps the same sign in every one.

FIGURE 3

The Lowest-Paid Fifth Leaves at the Highest Rate

Share of lead teachers leaving the program, by salary fifth, pooled 2021–22 to 2024–25



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2024–25.

Notes: Fifths of 1,150–1,151 lead-teacher records each. The association is descriptive; teachers who earn less differ in setting, experience, and location as well as pay.

This association is descriptive, because lower-paid teachers are also newer teachers in non-public settings, and these data cannot isolate pay from everything that travels with it. Although that limitation is a substantial one, the direction of the association is consistent, the gradient is steepest at the bottom of the distribution, and it aligns with the settings in which the previous briefs found the most churn. That alignment likely reflects the joint distribution of pay, experience, and setting rather than pay considered on its own.

Discussion

Between them, these patterns give parity proposals a set of magnitudes to reason about. The average teacher in other non-public settings sits roughly \$5,600 below schedule in salary and nearly \$17,000 below public peers in budgeted benefits, so any parity policy, whether schedule enforcement, benefit stipends, or tiered supplements, could be costed directly against those gaps, and the program's budget data would likely make classroom-level costing feasible.

Moreover, benefits may be the larger of the available levers, and they are certainly the quieter one. Salary gaps are visible in offer letters, whereas the divide in benefits is nearly invisible to a candidate until enrollment paperwork arrives. A benefits floor for non-public classrooms, even a partial one, would close the part of the total-compensation gap that candidates are least likely to see before they accept a position; at present, 32.1 percent of other non-public classrooms budget nothing.

Career progression is the third implication, and it is the one the salary schedule was meant to carry. A public-school teacher can expect an approximately \$17,300 climb over a career, whereas a Head Start

or other non-public teacher can expect \$3,100–\$3,600. If experienced teachers are worth retaining, and the turnover briefs suggest that they are, then flat non-public career paths are possibly where the program quietly loses its veterans.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. The salary–retention association does not estimate what raising pay would change, because teachers’ settings, experience, and communities move together with pay. Budgeted benefits are plans in the sense that budgets record intended spending rather than benefits teachers received, and salary records reflect rosters rather than payroll audits. Group means also hide spread, since some non-public settings pay at or above schedule and the means describe the centers of very different distributions. Finally, adequacy is out of scope, in that nothing reported here says what a pre-K teacher *should* earn, only how differently the same program’s teachers are compensated today.

The description stands on its own, in that one program working to one standard under one salary schedule operates two compensation systems, whose seam runs exactly where the workforce churns most.

References

- Lee, JoonHo, and Alison Hooper. 2026a. “Who Stays? Four Years of Teacher Turnover in First Class Pre-K.” Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama, Brief 6. Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama, College of Education.
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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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